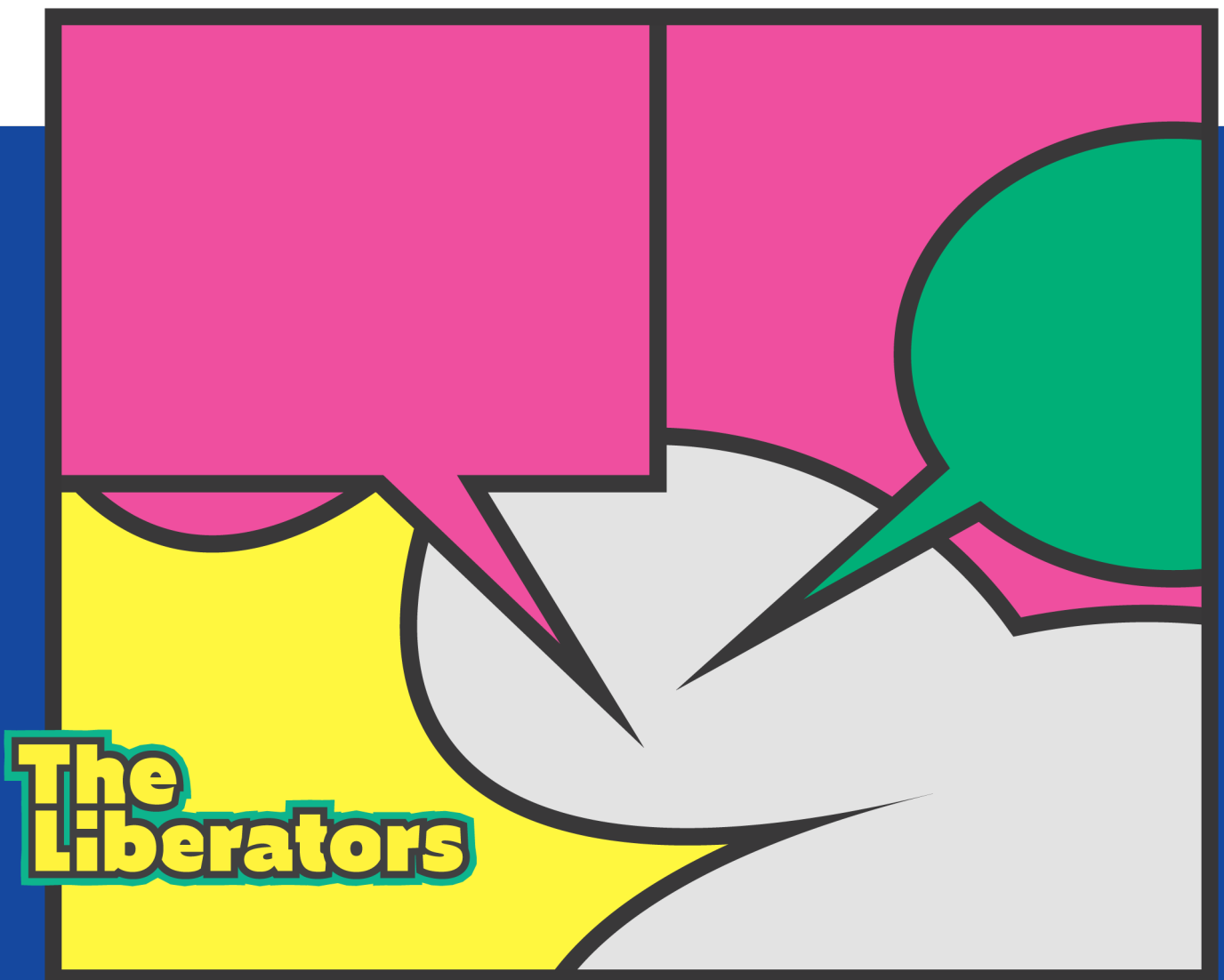


Team Toxins Workshop

A do-it-yourself workshop to create awareness of toxic conflict behavior as a necessary first step to eliminate and replace it with healthy, productive communication patterns



The Purpose Of This Workshop



This workshop aims to help teams and organizations identify and address the toxic behaviors and communication patterns that can damage relationships and hinder productivity.

During the workshop, participants learn about the various types of toxic behavior that can arise in a team setting, such as defensiveness, blaming, contempt, and stonewalling. They also learn strategies for recognizing and addressing these behaviors and techniques for improving communication and building more robust, productive relationships.

The workshop is designed to help teams and organizations foster a culture of respect, openness, and collaboration and minimize toxic behavior's harmful effects on team dynamics and overall performance. By addressing these issues proactively, teams can improve their ability to work together effectively, communicate clearly, and achieve their goals.

The concept of "team toxins" is based on the work of [Dr. John Gottman](#), a psychologist, and researcher who has spent decades studying relationships and communication patterns.

This workshop's inspiration comes from [Organization and Relationship Systems Coaching \(ORSC\)](#). [Barry Overeem](#) helped me to make it even more engaging and impactful using [Liberating Structures](#).

With the steps in this guide, you can run this workshop independently. But if you need help, do not hesitate to contact me at christian@hofstetter-coaching.com or reach out to me on [LinkedIn](#).

Let me know how it went!

Christian Hofstetter



Step 1: Hello Round



15 min

Step 2: Introducing Team Toxins



10 min

Step 3: Getting Familiar With Team Toxins



15 min

Step 4: How Are Team Toxins Trying to Be Helpful?



30 min

Step 5: Replacing Ineffective Behaviour



30 min

Step 6: Crafting Our Team Conflict Protocol



30 min

Step 7: Closing



20 min

Total duration

150 min



How To Prepare



Group Size

This Team Toxin workshop is suited for teams and groups from 3 up to 16 people.

Intended Audience

You can run this workshop with pretty much any audience – either as a team intervention or in form of a training (train-the-trainers, eg. Scrum Masters). The invitations and steps for this particular workshop are aimed for teams. If you want to run it in form of a training slight adaptations are needed.

Online Delivery

This workshop also works well online. For an online delivery you will need a video conferencing solution that offers breakout functionality. [Zoom](#) is ideal for this, but similar features are available in tools like [Teams](#) and [GotoMeeting](#). Also, a virtual whiteboard is an absolute must as participants will need to move around in form of placing a sticky note with their name on the four quadrants. [Mural](#), [Miro](#), or [Google Slides](#) work fairly well.

Material

- A roll of blue tape, to mark four quadrants on the floor
- Pen and paper for participants to write on
- A set of Team Toxin cards containing the four team toxins, symptoms, and antidotes (see Resources)
- Place chairs in a circle, make sure to have an empty space of at least 4 by 4 meters. Put tables aside.

Resources

- Team Toxin Cards: [PDF](#)



Step 1: Hello Round

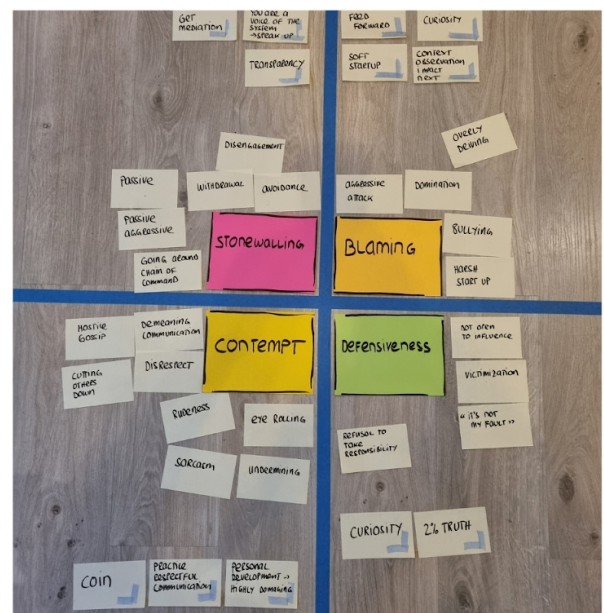
The purpose of the "Hello Round" is to set a positive tone for the workshop and create a safe space for the participants. If the workshop is conducted with a small number of participants (3-6 people), it is also possible to skip the splitting up into pairs and invite everyone to share their story with the whole team.

Invitation

"Share something positive."

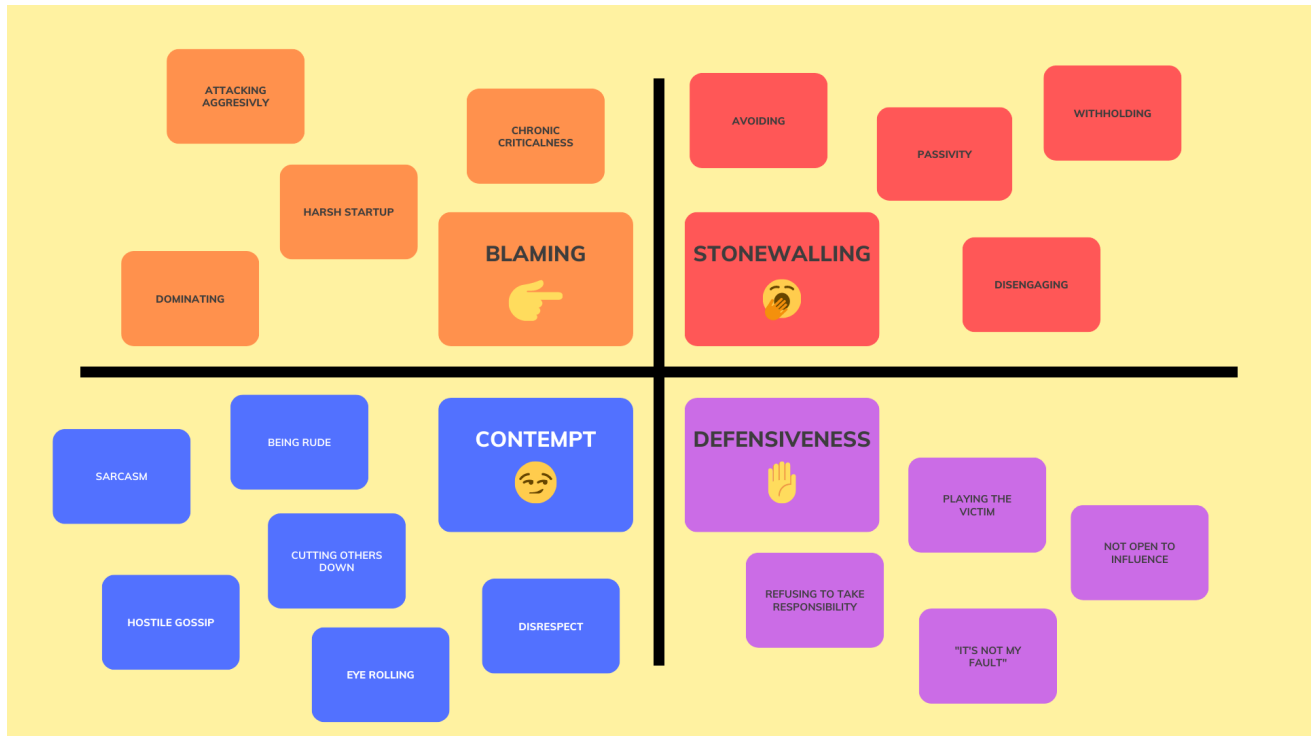
Steps

1. Open the workshop by welcoming the participants and inviting them to sit down on their chairs.
2. Explain the steps very briefly.
3. Ask participants to share their stories in pairs for 3 minutes. Let them be mindful of each other and share the responsibility for the timebox.
4. **10 min** After 3 minutes, ding the bell and ask people to form new pairs.





Step 2: Introducing Team Toxins



Introducing the concept of team toxins aims to help team members recognize negative behaviours and communication patterns that can harm team performance and provide them with tools to address and reduce these toxic behaviours to improve team collaboration and productivity.

In this step, you educate the participants about the four team toxins and the symptoms that help you spot and identify them.

Steps

1. Lay a quadrant on the floor with a space for each of the four team toxins. Label each quadrant with the name of the toxins. This also works perfectly fine on a virtual whiteboard.
2. **1 min** Explain that this exercise is designed to help teams understand and take responsibility for their toxic communication patterns. Before starting the activity, it is essential to educate the team about the team toxins and familiarize them with the research on the harmful team toxins and the importance of creating a positive work environment. Put down the cards with the symptoms one by one.
3. **5 min** Introduce the four team toxins and their symptoms using the cards

Symptoms

Blaming

- **Aggressive attack:** In a team meeting, a member might raise their voice, interrupt others, or use aggressive language to make their point.
- **Harsh start-up:** A team member might begin a conversation or feedback session with negative or critical language, such as "You're not doing this right" or "I can't believe you didn't think of this."
- **Chronic criticalness:** A team member might consistently find fault with others' ideas or contributions, nitpick at

small details, or focus on the negative aspects of a situation.

- **Domination:** A team member might try to control the conversation or decision-making process, refusing to listen to others' perspectives or take their input into account.

Defensiveness

- **Playing the victim:** A team member might deflect criticism or feedback by portraying themselves as victims of circumstances or other people's actions.
- **Not open to influence:** A team member might resist new ideas or different perspectives, insisting that their way is the only way.
- **Refusing to take responsibility:** A team member might deflect blame or responsibility for mistakes or failures by blaming others or insisting that the situation was out of their control.
- **"It's not my fault":** A team member might be defensive and dismissive in response to criticism or feedback, insisting that they did nothing wrong or that the other person is overreacting.

Stonewalling

- **Avoiding:** A team member might avoid a difficult conversation or conflict by refusing to participate, changing the subject, or simply not attending a meeting.
- **Passivity:** A team member might respond to questions or feedback with short, non-committal answers or passive body language, such as avoiding eye contact or slouching in their chair.
- **Disengaging:** A team member might withdraw from the conversation or task at hand by physically leaving the room or mentally checking out.
- **Withholding:** A team member might withhold important information or feedback that could be useful.

Contempt

- **Being rude:** A team member might speak to others disrespectfully or condescendingly, using language that implies superiority or disdain.
- **Sarcasm:** A team member might use sarcasm to make fun of others or express displeasure.
- **Hostile gossip:** A team member might spread harmful or hurtful rumours or gossip about others in the team or the organization.
- **Cutting others down:** A team member might belittle others' ideas or contributions or make personal attacks on others.
- **Eye rolling:** A team member might roll their eyes or use other nonverbal cues to express disrespect or disdain for others in the team.
- **Disrespect:** A team member might treat others in the team with disrespect, such as interrupting others, disregarding others' opinions or ideas, or using language that is dismissive or insulting.

Our Findings

- Keep this teaching block short, as you want the participants to move into action right after. Refrain from over-explain.

Resources

- Team Toxin Cards: [PDF](#)
- Research on The Four Horsemen by Dr. Gottman: [Blog](#)





Step 3: Getting Familiar With Team Toxins

After the short teaching block, you want the participants to move into action. Invite them to explore the four team toxins by reflecting on the visible behavior from a team they have been on in the past.

Invitation

Think of a team you have been a member of. Step into the toxin quadrant you think is mainly occupied by the team.

Steps

1. **1 min** While seated, ask team members to think of a team they have been on in the past.
2. **1 min** Have the team members step into the quadrant they think is most commonly occupied by the team.
3. It is ok if not all quadrants are equally occupied. A personal connection is more important than having all four quadrants filled. Within the quadrants, build groups of 3.
4. **3 min** Discuss within the groups: "In each quadrant, come up with a stance, sound, or gesture of that toxin."
5. **5 min** Discuss within your quadrant: "What were the situations that brought that toxin out in that team?"
6. **5 min** Debrief from all four quadrants, briefly and high level, starting with the gesture.

Our Findings

- As a facilitator, keep it playful. This makes it easier for participants to show themselves vulnerable.
- It is advised to choose a team they have been part of in the past rather than the current one. A high degree of psychological safety, trust, and experience running this workshop is highly recommended if you want to focus on the current team.

Resources

- Team Toxin Cards: [PDE](#)





Step 4: How Are Team Toxins Trying to Be Helpful?

In the previous step, we looked at the downsides of team toxins. This step aims to normalize this toxic behaviour and understand how they are helpful and which vulnerabilities they try to protect.

Invitation

Think about how your team toxin is trying to be helpful.

Steps

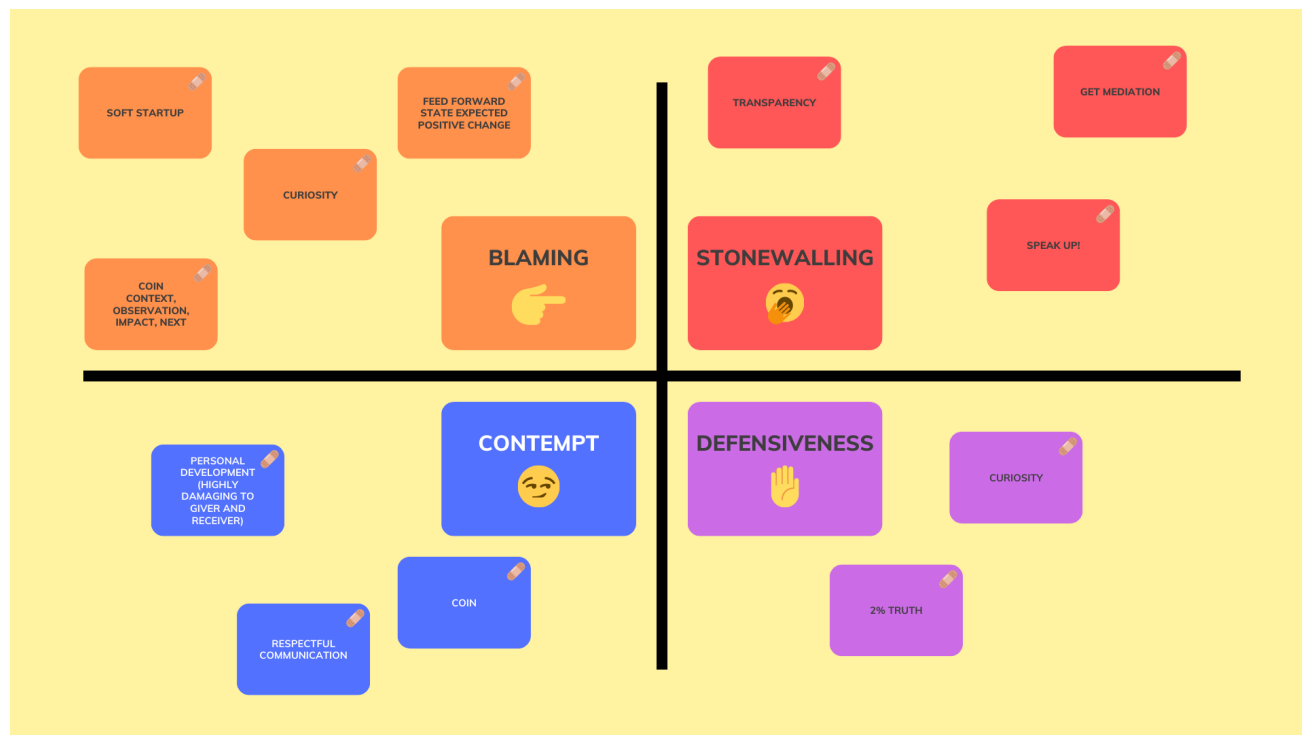
1. Return them to their conversation in their quadrant with the request to investigate what is underneath the toxin. Drill down to the vulnerability it protects (fear, impotence, shame, guilt).
2. **5 min** First individually, then in small groups (same quadrant): "What is the belief/emotion behind this toxin? How is it trying to be helpful?" It is not a very skilful way, but it is in service of something. What is it in service of? Example: I may act defensively because I feel misunderstood and want you to understand me.
3. **10 min** Hear from everyone on the team. This is where the real possibility for change lies, so spend time here.
4. As a facilitator, notice what toxin quadrants are not occupied and ask about them.
5. Ask: "Go to the quadrant that you personally most often employ. (your GOTO toxin)." Facilitator, model this by revealing your favourite toxin and keeping it light and playful.
6. **5 min** "Have a short conversation with the person next to you: What situations bring it out in you? What is the toxin trying to protect?"
7. **10 min** Allow time for participants to share with everyone

Our Findings

- It is ok if some of the toxin quadrants are not occupied. Address it and ask about it.



Step 5: Replacing Ineffective Behaviour



Understanding how small behaviour shifts (known as antidotes) can help your team stop harmful behaviour and take one small step to let go of your unhealthy behaviour.

Invitation

Pick an antidote that you are willing to practice in the next few weeks. What is your next step to letting go of the ineffective behaviour? Something you do not need any additional resources, permission, or authority to do right now.

Steps

1. Place the antidote cards in the four quadrants. Don't explain them yet.
2. **3 min** Every quadrant prepares a one-minute teach-back session about the antidotes in their quadrant.
3. **5 min** Every quadrant presents their antidotes to the whole group. Fill the gaps as facilitator where needed.
4. **3 min** "Individually, pick an antidote that you are willing to practice in the next few weeks. What is your next step to letting go of the ineffective behaviour? Something you do not need any additional resources, permission, or authority to do right now?"
5. **8 min** "In pairs, share your next step and coach each other to make it even smaller, more likely that you will follow through."
6. **10 min** Everyone shares your next step with the team.

Antidotes

Blaming



- **Soft startup:** A team member might initiate a conversation or feedback session in a non-confrontational and respectful way, such as by expressing appreciation for the other person's contributions or by asking open-ended questions to invite dialogue.
- **Curiosity:** A team member might approach a situation with a sense of curiosity and a desire to understand the other person's perspective rather than assuming that they already know the answer.
- **Feed forward:** A team member might provide feedback focused on future growth and improvement rather than dwelling on past mistakes or assigning blame.
- **COIN (Context, Observation, Impact, Next):** A team member might use the COIN model to provide feedback in a way that is clear, specific, and non-judgmental. By providing context for the situation, making observations based on facts, describing the impact of the behaviour, and suggesting next steps, team members can give constructive and actionable feedback.

Defensiveness

- **2% truth:** If a team member is being defensive and making blanket statements or exaggerating their position, another team member may point out the small grain of truth in their statement to acknowledge their perspective.
- **Curiosity**

Stonewalling

- **Transparency:** If a team member feels overwhelmed or stressed and has difficulty participating fully in team meetings or projects, they may communicate this transparently to the team.
- **Get mediation:** If there is a conflict between team members and one or more team members are avoiding communication or engagement, a team leader or HR representative may intervene and offer mediation services to facilitate open dialogue and work towards a resolution.
- **Speak up:** If a team member feels disconnected from the team or struggles to engage fully, they may speak up and communicate this to the team.

Contempt

- **Personal development:** If a team member recognizes that they have a tendency to express contempt towards others, they may take steps to work on their personal development, such as attending anger management classes, practicing mindfulness, or seeking therapy.
- **Respectful communication:** If a team member expresses contemptuous behavior towards others, another team member may model respectful communication by focusing on the issue and avoiding personal attacks or insults.
- **COIN**





Step 6: Crafting Our Team Conflict Protocol

A team conflict protocol aims to provide a framework for managing conflicts constructively and productively, with the ultimate goal of improving team dynamics and performance. It can create a more harmonious and productive team environment where conflicts are managed effectively and positively.

Invitation

Think about your ideal team: how would that team handle conflict and disagreements?

What are some behaviours you want to have to happen when conflict occurs?

What are some behaviours you do not want to have to happen when conflict occurs?

It takes 6–9 months to change behaviour. How will you hold each other accountable for following these agreements? What will you do if someone breaks an agreement?

Write down the dos for handling conflict within our team.

Write down the don'ts for handling conflict within our team.

What is the one thing we have to focus on as a team?

Steps

1. Invite everyone to get out a blank sheet of paper and a pen.
2. **10 min** Answer the prompts individually (approx. 1 minute per prompt)
3. **5 min** In pairs, share your answers, and decide on three dos and don'ts for handling conflict in the team
4. **5 min** In groups of four, share your answers, and decide on three dos and don'ts for handling conflict in the team
5. **10 min** As a team, agree on three dos and don'ts for handling conflict in the team

Our Findings

- The three dos and don'ts for handling conflict in the team can be added to the team's working agreements.



Step 7: Closing

Before closing this workshop it is beneficial to pause for a short moment and let the team reflect on what just happened. Debriefing a team workshop using the following four questions effectively promotes learning, collaboration, and continuous improvement within a team.

Invitation

"What did we do great as a team today?"

"What could we have done better as a team?"

"What did we learn about each other?"

"What will we do about it?"

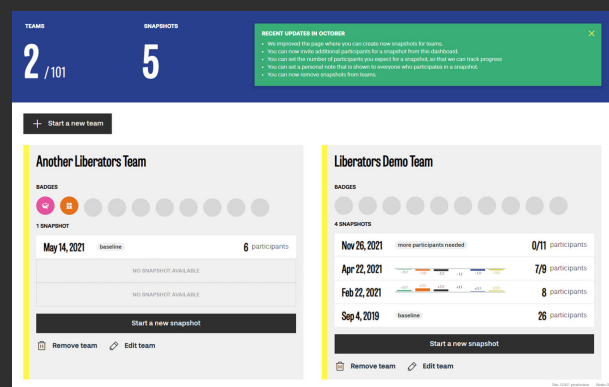
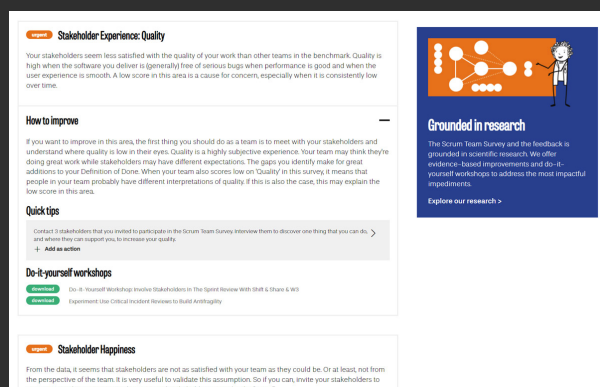
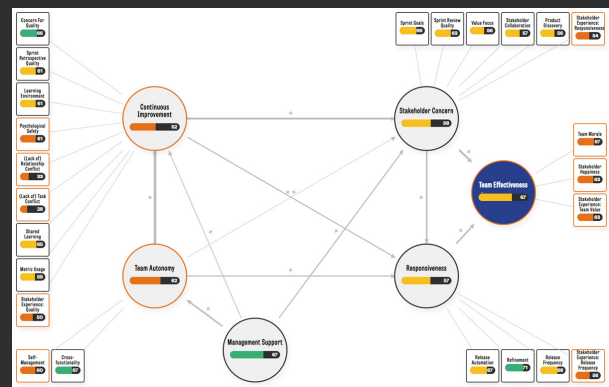
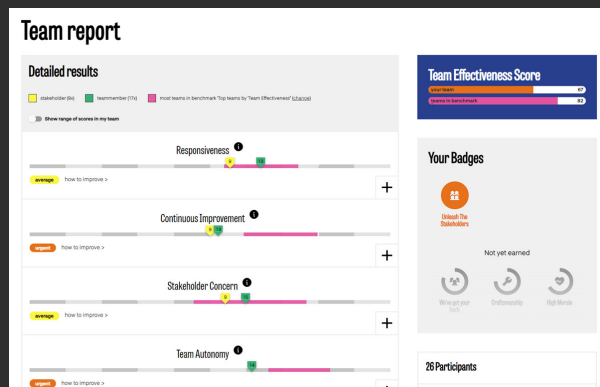
Steps

1. **10 min** Ask participants to reflect on in pairs for 2 minutes on each of the four prompts.
2. **5 min** Let the pairs share their insights and actions with the whole group.
3. **3 min** Thank the participants and close the workshop.



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